The GIMP 2.6

Reaching Newer Heights

Getting your hands dirty with the latest version.

The GIMP, or the GNU Image Manipulation Program, is one of the most powerful free and open source raster image editing software. It rose from the ashes of a hideously crafted class project under the name of General Image Manipulation Program by Spencer Kimball and Peter Mattis. Later on, it was merged into the GNU Project and is often considered a replacement for the icy-pricey Adobe Photoshop.

Until recently, the diverse GIMP was very much a mixed bag—too perplexing for newbies on the one hand while requiring high-end colour channels and plug-ins support. Besides, its meagre 8-bit colour support (instead of 32-bit) and complex UI was a major barrier in its adoption among professionals.

Finally, after eight years of planning, the developers took a major leap in GIMP development. The spanking new GIMP 2.6 was introduced, loaded with GEGL, a CMYX/32-bit colour channel, minor UI changes and a plethora of nifty add-ons and plug-ins.

On October 1, 2008, the venerable raster image editor got refurbished with a new version 2.6.x. The major change in this version lies in the core of the software—the addition of GEGL, a powerful graph-based image-editing framework.

Let's take an in-depth look at what the newer GIMP has to offer. In this review, I will be using the third revision of the latest GIMP—that is, GIMP 2.6.3, which provides significant improvements over the basic release.

When initiating the GIMP, you will be

GEGL and CMYK integration

GEGL, or Generic Graphics Library, is a powerful graph-based image-editing framework. The most enticing reason for developers to opt for GEGL is its library functions, which can deal with the 32-bit colour channel. In addition to this, GEGL supports the CMYK (cyan, magenta, yellow and 'k' for black) colour model, which is used in high quality colour printing.

Previous versions of the GIMP had support only for 8-bit colour channels, which was a setback for raw formats, and thus owners of high-end digital cameras were forced to opt for paid alternatives. The newer version paved the way for GIMP's acceptance and future development.